City Attorney's Impartial Analysis of Measure J
for the November 3, 2026 Election

***** Start Analysis *****

Measure J, the City of Palo Alto Community Safety/Services Measure, would authorize a 0.5% (one-half of one percent) increase to the transactions and use tax (commonly known as a sales tax) in the City of Palo Alto. The Palo Alto City Council placed this measure on the ballot by unanimous vote. This measure requires approval by a simple majority of voters voting on the measure and will remain in effect unless it is repealed by the voters. The City estimates that this measure will generate revenues of approximately $15.6 million per year.

Measure J is a general tax, meaning that proceeds of the tax will be deposited in the City's general fund and can be used for any lawful governmental purpose. In June 2026, the City Council passed a resolution adopting advisory spending guidelines that stated the Council's intention to use the proceeds to purchase seven-acres of the Cubberley Community Center from the Palo Alto Unified School District. The advisory spending guidelines also state Council's intention to modernize the Cubberley Community Center. The plan includes renovation of some existing buildings, new construction, and new outdoor park spaces.

If approved, the new sales tax rate would become effective in April 2027.

Measure J changes nothing else about the local sales tax. What items are taxable, the method of collection, implementation, exemptions, and other provisions would remain unchanged.

If this measure does not pass, the local sales tax will not increase by the 0.5% proposed in this measure, and the City of Palo Alto will not receive an estimated $15.6 million in revenue per year from the tax.

A "yes" vote is a vote to approve a 0.5% increase to the transactions and use tax (commonly known as a sales tax) within the City.

A "no" vote is a vote not to approve the increase to the transactions and use tax.

Christopher D. Jensen
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City of Palo Alto

***** End Analysis *****

FILED
AUG 18 2026
REGISTRAR OF VOTERS
COUNTY OF SANTA CLARA
By [redacted] Deputy